



Ending on a high: Coco Gauff, who split with Brad Gilbert and hired Matt Daley after the US Open, salvaged her otherwise disappointing year at the WTA Finals. GETTYIMAGES

we'd been waiting for — and the one her late father Sergey, a former ice hockey player, had predicted she would become. Sabalenka recalled, "He told me then that I had everything I needed to achieve this goal: I just had to learn myself better, learn how to control my emotions, and one day I'd be world number one. It was like our dream."

Their dream came true on September 11, 2023, though Sabalenka finished the year ranked No. 2 behind Swiatek. Indeed, the lean, 5'11", broad-shouldered Belarusian has everything: an ideal tennis physique, superb strokes and footwork, athleticism, and newly added finesse to complement her tremendous power.

However, doubts persisted about her mental toughness even after Sabalenka overcame Elena Rybakina in the 2023 Australian Open final for her first Grand Slam title. She subsequently suffered disappointing three-set upset losses to Karolina

Muchova at Roland Garros, Ons Jabeur at Wimbledon, and, most dishearteningly, Coco Gauff in the memorable US Open final.

At the 2024 Australian Open, a more relaxed and confident Sabalenka pummeled No. 9 seed Barbora Krejčíková 6-2, 6-3 in the quarterfinals and then spoke about a score to settle with rising star Gauff. "I love it. After [the 2023] US Open, I really wanted that revenge," Sabalenka said. "It's always great battles against Coco, with really great fights. I'm happy to play her, and I'm super excited to play that semifinal."

Highly animated but far less agitated this season, the new Sabalenka relentlessly attacked Gauff's second serve, claimed the critical first-set tiebreak 7-2, and prevailed 7-6 (2), 6-4.

Major upsets decimated the top

seeds in the other half of the draw. Swiatek, who struggles against power players, was ousted by Linda Noskova, a 19-year-old Czech, 3-6, 6-3, 6-4. Russia's unheralded Anna Blinkova outlasted No. 3 seed and 2022 Wimbledon champion Elena Rybakina 6-4, 4-6, 7-6 (20). The fluctuating tiebreak — in which Blinkova fended off six match points before prevailing on her tenth — prompted *ESPN* analyst Pam Shriver to remark, "You don't see 16 match points, maybe once in a lifetime."

The carnage opened up the draw for No. 12 Zheng Qinwen to reach the final without facing a seeded player. The tournament invited China's Li Na, Zheng's childhood idol, to honour her on the 10th anniversary of her historic title there, and she surprised the delighted Zheng in the clubhouse lounge. The Hall of Famer and the blossoming star hugged and chatted, with Li advising her to "keep it simple and not overthink."

Neither that good advice nor vocal front-row Chinese spectators in red hats were enough to help Zheng dethrone Sabalenka in the final. Both finalists played "first-strike" power tennis, though Sabalenka did it much better. Opponents could no longer rely on her double faults — once her *bête noire* — as Sabalenka committed just 10 in her first six matches and none in the final. Summing up Sabalenka's 6-3, 6-2 masterclass, *ESPN* analyst Mary Joe Fernandez commented, "There are no holes in Sabalenka's game. This is as dominant a performance as you'll see in a Grand Slam final."



Zheng Qinwen won the Paris Olympics gold medal at Roland Garros after upsetting the Queen of Clay, Iga Swiatek, in a shocking semifinal.